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Sony SRS-XB-13

A small and handy speaker for outdoor use

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pening up an audio product with the Sony logo on it remains as exciting as ever.

Within the box is the speaker enclosed within a soft pouch, a twelve inch long USB type C charging cable, a pictographic instruction manual, a text heavy reference guide, and the warranty card (which lasts for a year).

BUILD AND DESIGN

The speaker is three and a half inches tall, three inches wide, and weighs about 250 grams. This is designed to be a small and lightweight speaker, meant for the outdoors. On the top is the main driver, pointed upwards. Beneath the device, pointing downwards is a passive radiator, which is a smart but obvious place to incorporate one in such a small form factor.

There is a handy strap that can attach itself to the side of the bag in

two configurations, one where the speaker dangles down from the side, and another where it is more securely attached at two points. There is an S shaped clip, which is a pretty smart design that allows you to quickly switch between the two configurations, allowing the speaker to be easily hung on everything from trees to gear hooks within tents.

The speaker is waterproof and dust-proof with an IP67 rating. We tested it out in the rain and faced no problems. The speaker itself feels sturdy, and is completely satisfactory as a hardy outdoor speaker in terms of build quality.

The power and volume rocker buttons are located on a rubber strip towards the base of the device, with a flap that opens up to the USB-C port.

FEATURES

The speaker only has the necessary features for its intended function,



Price
₹3,990



BUILD	85
FEATURES	54
PERFORMANCE	83
VALUE	92

stripping away all the extra bells and whistles. There is no WiFi connectivity, or voice assistant support, and the companion app does not work with this particular model. The only feature that we wish the speaker had, was support from the Sony Music Centre app,

if only to look at the battery capacity of the device. Fortunately, the device makes up for this by having a long battery life, and a dedicated LED indicator to show that it needs to charge up.

There is also Google's Fast Pair tech, which allows superfast pairing with Android devices, using Bluetooth Low Energy. This actually works like magic on some supported Android devices, where you get a notification on the device if the speaker is turned on anywhere in the vicinity. Tap on it once, and it gets paired.

The only other feature of note offered by the speaker is a mic that allows you to answer calls. The mic is located below the control buttons, and does not perform very well at a distance. You can just about use it around arm's length without raising your voice, but you will find yourself grabbing it and talking into the mic to be more clear, so it is not really something

that one would prefer to use, but is a functional alternative if your phone is charging elsewhere.

BATTERY AND PERFORMANCE

The battery life is really good. We played it at around fifty percent volume and it lasted well over a day of continuous playback, well beyond the 16 hours on the box, which we assume are at higher volumes. The Bluetooth connection does get jittery from time to time, with the audio playback stuttering or distorted playback. When this happens, usually turning off the device and turning it on is enough to fix this problem, which is infrequent anyway.

As for sound, the highs and mids are clear and distinct. The bass is a bit problematic, while the speakers are bass forward, they do not really pack in a punch. It is also difficult to reconcile buyer expectations with reality in a review. The most critical thing here is that the bass sounds much better when the speaker is dangled, the way it is meant to be used, reflected off sundry surfaces such as tent tops, tree tops and umbrella tops. To sum up, the mids and highs sound great, and the bass is just about right without being excessive.

VERDICT

While the official MRP is 4,990, the device is actually available on ecommerce sites for up to a thousand rupees cheaper than that, which makes it a really attractive proposition. Considering the quality of the device, it seems to have been priced just right, but we wish that Sony would make the deal sweeter for those who want to pick up a pair. The Sony SRS-XB13 is a small, lightweight but hardy speaker meant for outdoor use.

—Aditya Madanapalle

SPECIFICATIONS

DIMENSIONS: 76 mm dia. × 95 mm | WEIGHT: 253 g
| PLAYBACK TIME: 16 hours | MAX COMMUNICATION RANGE: 10 m

CONTACT

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